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"Serve the People" from 1944 to 2005

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Abstract In 1944 Mao Zedong published a speech titled "Serve the People" to commemorate the death of an Eighth Route Army Soldier, Zhang Side, a participant in the Long March who died in the collapse of a kiln. The notion "Serve the People" is regarded as one of Mao's most significant theoretical contributions to the understanding and application of Marxism in China. In the post-Mao era, "Serve the People" developed into one of the key words and slogans of the Communist Party in China and has significant influence both domestically and internationally. While in 2005, Yan Lianke, one of China's foremost contemporary novelists, published a novella of the same title featuring another PLA soldier, Wu Dawang, a model soldier selected to work as a household servant for a powerful Division Commander. The political speech and the fiction have a strong interrelationship as the meaning of "serving the people" undergoes dramatic changes. By borrowing and transforming the meaning of this well-known phrase, Yan metaphorically reveals his objection to political injustice in China. This essay aims to compare and contrast these two pieces, centering on the analysis of the issues: "Who are 'the people'?" so as to reveal Yan's metaphoric writing strategy. The ultimate purpose of this essay is to search for further understanding of justice in a global sense. Though the novella is written in a Chinese context, its implication and significance goes beyond any particular political regime.

Keywords Yan Lianke · Intertexuality · Justice · Fear

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Introduction

Since the poststructuralist Julia Kristeva introduced the term "intertextuality" in 1966, it has been widely applied to interpret the literary formation of texts that have interrelationship between each other. "By bracketting the question of semantic sequences, one can bring out the logical practice organizing them, thus proceeding at a suprasegmental level." (Kristeva 1980, p.37) The meaning of the text is not transferred directly from writers to readers but instead, it is mediated through other texts. Whether it is called allusion, calque, pastiche or parody, it adequately explains how a writer's intentional or unintentional borrowing and transformation of a prior text add further layers of depth to a newly generated text. And Yan Lianke's *Serve the People* is a typical example which shows how he uses this literary discourse to link a novella[1] with reference to a political slogan which was widely promoted in the past and is still in use nowadays in China. French theorist Gérard Genette also coined a similar term "Hypertextuality" which "refers to any relationship uniting a text B (which I shall call the hypertext) to an earlier text A (I shall, of course, call it the hypotext), upon which it is grafted in a manner that is not that of commentary."[2] Thus it is argued that the intertexuality about "serve the people" here relies on the reader's full comprehension of its prior hypotext, so as to achieve the further comprehension of the hypertext.

Serve the people: the hypotext

"Serve the People" is a political slogan which was paid attention to in Mao-era China from a same-titled speech by Mao Zedong (Mao Tse-tung), delivered on September 8, 1944. Mao wrote this speech to commemorate the death of Zhang Side, an Eighth Route Army Soldier who participated in the Long March and died in the collapse of a kiln. In this speech Mao made a reference to a phrase by the historian Sima Qian in the Han Dynasty, "Though death befalls all men alike, it may be heavy as Mount Tai or light as a feather."[3] And he continued: "To die for the people is weightier than Mount Tai, but to work for the fascists and die for the exploiters and oppressors is lighter than a feather. Comrade Zhang Side died for the people, and his death is indeed weightier than Mount Tai."[4] Because the phrase "serve the people" is the title of the speech, it attracted much attention and was regarded as the origin of this notion by Mao. In fact, before the speech, the notion of serving the people has been emphasized many times by Mao. He believes that Marxism is a theoretical doctrine to guide the struggle for Chinese people's interests, rather than for the individual's personal gain. As early as January 28,

[1] The first Chinese version of "Serve the People" was published in 2005 in Hua Cheng, a leading Chinese literary journal and then the government ordered the issue recalled. However the citation of sentences out of this fiction is based on the English version of the fiction translated by Julia Lovell.

[2] Genette (1997, p. 5).

[3] Mao (1966, p. 3).

[4] Ibid.

1921, Mao expressed his understanding about this notion in a letter: "I believe that we have dispute on doctrines, which is not personal dispute. The dispute on doctrines is obligatory, as it's for people's doctrine, not for personal matters."[5] Mao has realized that to emphasize the interests of the masses of people, or to serve the people is a necessity, and it turns out that the victory of the Communist Party over Guomindang (Nationalists) is the former's relying on the masses, or to put it in another way, serving the people is the key factor that results in the Communist Party's wresting the political power over the nation from Guomingdang. After the release of the speech "Serve the People" in 1944, this phrase was repeatedly used on different occasions first by Mao himself and gradually became the key phrase and political token of the Chinese Communist Party.

The following excerpts are chosen and presented in a chronological order to review how "Serve the People" develops into Chinese Communist Party's political token as well as Mao's catchphrase. On December 15, 1944, 3 months after the release of the speech "Serve the People", in the essay titled "Task of 1945", Mao said: "all our cadres, regardless of rank, are servants of the people. All that we have done, is to serve the people, and then is there any bad thing that we are not willing to throw away?"[6] On April 24, 1945, at the Seventh CCP Congress, Mao further proposed a tenet of "serving the people wholeheartedly" in a report titled "On Coalition Government": "serve the people wholeheartedly, at no moment isolate from masses and always start from people's interests, instead of from certain personal or factions' interests. It is our starting point to be consistent in being responsible both for people and for the Party's leading organ."[7] From this point on, "serving the people" became the guiding principle of the whole CCP. On August 13, 1945, in the essay titled "The Current Political Situation after the Victory and Our Policy," Mao emphasized: "our responsibility is to be accountable to the people. Every word, every action, every policy should suit the interests of the people. If there is any error, it should be corrected, and this is being accountable to the people."[8] On February 27, 1957, in the essay titled "On Handling of Contradictions among the People Correctly", Mao said: "the government organs carry out democratic centralism and the staff in government organs must serve the people."[9]And 1 month later, Mao said in another article titled "Insisting on Hard Work, Stay Close With the Masses" that "the Communist Party is to struggle, and to serve the people wholeheartedly, not half-hearted or two-thirds of heart two-thirds of soul."[10] He understands the power of the people, and said in the 1960s,

> Power comes from the people. If people's requests are not reflected, there is no use. We should learn the knowledge from the people, lay down policies, and then educate the masses. So if one wants to be a teacher, he must be a student

[5] Mao (2003, p. 14).

[6] Mao (1996, Volume 3, p. 243).

[7] Mao (1991, Volume 3, pp. 1094–1095).

[8] Mao (1991, Volume 4, p. 1128).

[9] Mao (1999a, b, Volume 7, p. 240).

[10] Mao (1999a, b, Volume 7, p. 285).

first, and there is no teacher who has not been a student before. What's more, even after becoming a teacher, one should also learn from the people, and know about students' situation."[11]

He further summarized Marxism for the Party members: "Among our cadres, many are self-righteous. One of the reasons is that they do not understand the epistemology of Marxism. Therefore, it is of crucial importance to repeatedly advocate this kind of epistemology to them. And to put it in a simple way, it is to come from the masses and to go back into the masses."[12]

On different occasions Mao wrote the calligraphy of "serving the people" for different sorts of people and groups, such as various sorts of schools, Communist Party and government officials, the martyrs and their families, and staff members serving him such as nurses and guards.

Looking back on Mao's life, though he has not carried out a theoretical research of Marxism formally in any educational institutions, as an astute politician and book lover, he was able to combine Marxism with his dynamic understanding of the situations and then quickly summarized it into one fundamental truth that the Communist Party must serve the people or the masses so as to get their support. So he emphasized that the Chinese Communist Party should always be selfless, always serve the people heart and soul and always adhere to the principle of being people-oriented.

The concept of "Serving the People", together with "Seeking Truth from Facts" became the core principles of CCP. And these two catchphrases are still carved on the front and back of a huge stone right behind the front gate in the Central Party School of the CCP, which carries the original autograph of Mao. And many scholars in China believe that "serve the people" is the core of Maoism.

Moreover, the phrase is still used in the ceremony of China's People's Liberation Army's troop inspection. During the inspection of troops, the following 4 sentences are always spoken for certain. Sentence 1 is uttered by the Inspecting official: "Greetings, Comrades!" Sentence 2 by the troops: "Greetings, Leader!" Sentence 3 by the Inspecting official: "Comrades [you] have worked hard." And the troops reply with sentence 4: "Serve the people!" The implication of the last sentence is that those soldiers are willing to work hard for the interests of the people.

"Serve the People" is not only the tenet of Maoism and leading principle of CCP and PLA, for besides its popularity in China, the slogan "Serve the People" was also once widely used in the United States by students and youth during their political movement of the late 1960s and 1970s due to the strong Maoist influence on the New Left. The slogan was very popular amongst the Red Guard Party, the Black Panther Party, and the Yellow Brotherhood of West Los Angeles. Now at City of Santa Ana, California, there is a non-profit charity organization which also names itself "Serve the people" and they give people free pantry bag and free legal aid. The significance of "Serving the people" the phrase itself lies in the love and

[11] Mao (1999a, b, Volume 8, p. 324).

[12] Ibid.

responsibility that a noble person could possess and spread in a society and the justice that was strived for by all people.

Serve the People: the hypertext

One citation of Mao's words is of particular significance to this essay. On the 21st of September, 1966, Mao pointed out that "[E]ach of us Communist Party member should consider the masses: the leading officers in the military troops should consider the soldiers, the leading officials in the organizations and colleges should consider the canteen staff and the orderlies."Here the "soldiers" and "orderlies" are clearly stated to be members of "people", and should be served. But ironically, in the fiction *Serve the People*, the orderly Wu Dawang, is not served, instead he is told that "serve the people" is to "serve the Division Commander and his wife" by his Political Instructor.

There are usually two ways for the author to make allusions to a hypotext: one is the implied way, in which the author does not state directly the connection between the hypotext and the hypertext, and challenges readers to probe the unspoken intertexuality between the texts by themselves; the other is the direct way, in which the author intentionally and openly links the two texts together. Obviously, in the fiction *Serve the People* the author Yan Lianke applies the latter way. He not only repeats the title in his fiction, at the beginning of his novella, he also makes use of the following citation from Mao's 1944 speech as the prologue[13]:

> We hail from all corners of our country and have gathered here with one common revolutionary objective in mind. The vast majority of people need to come with us on the road to this objective. … In difficult times our comrades must not lose sight of our successes, they must recognize our bright future, and must pluck up their courage. …Our officers must be mindful of every soldier, and every member of every revolutionary battalion must look after each other, and must love and help each other.[14]

The nobleness of this sublime statement which has been and is still highly referred to in promoting the honorable responsibility of the communist party is subverted by Yan Lianke in such an ironic way, that the sense of deconstruction becomes obvious. The following section will analyze his process of deconstruction and construction step by step.

Because the 28-year-old model soldier, Wu Dawang could perfectly recite Mao's writings and was good at preparing various courses of food, he is sent to the house of the Division Commander and works as an orderly. As what is mentioned in the previous section, in the military inspection, when soldiers in the troops reply to the praise of the inspecting official's comment: "You have worked hard" with "serve the people." The underlying rationale is that they deem it a meaningful and

[13] In the English version, the whole section of Mao Zedong's speech is put at the end of the book as an attachment.

[14] Yan (2007, pp. 227–228).

honorable thing, because their hard work will indirectly serve the people. Wu Dawang takes his orderly job happily with the same sort of reasoning, believing that he is serving the people through serving the Division Commander and his wife, for the Division Commander is trying his best to serve other people. Unfortunately with the development of the plots, readers would find that there is a possibility that the phrase could be misused, and the implication could be changed.

In the beginning of the fiction Wu Dawang joyfully accepts this new role, because on the one hand it is an honor to serve the Division Commander, on the other hand because he strives for promotion and dreams of bringing his family members City Hukou[15] through fulfilling this duty. At that time in China, there was tremendous difference between being a city dweller and a peasant. Getting promotion onto a certain rank in the army is the only way for him to break this entrenchment of social strata, and get himself and his family members a chance for a better life. So Wu Dawang's rationale should be serving the people and getting promotion together with City Hukou.

The fiction develops around a wooden sign that bears the Chinese characters of "Serve the People!" which was brought back by the Division Commander himself and put on the kitchen table. According to the description "This sign, its letters burning scarlet against the whitewashed background, its stars, rifle, canteen and wheat emblazoned in red and yellow, had come home 1 day with the Division Commander."[16] When the Division Commander puts the sign there, he also questions Wu's understanding of it and gives him the hint to pay special attention to it. "And from that moment on, the sign became the most distinguished, most illustrious resident of the dining table, casting its mighty symbolic shadow over the lowly bottles of vinegar, chili sauce and sesame oil."[17] To Wu Dawang, to serve the people means to serve the Division Commander and his wife especially! He worked for the family for 6 months heart and soul.

While, the other main character of the fiction— the Division Commander's wife, 32-year-old Liu Lian, who is almost 20 years younger than her husband, is also aware of the significance or function of "serving the people" and she interprets and illustrates it in her own rationale: "Serve the people—I am the people—If you cannot serve me—You have to go". When the Division Commander is away from home for a long period of time, Liu Lian starts her act of taming the orderly Wu Dawang and teaching him who is "the people". She is like a hunter, hunting for her prey, Wu Dawang. She told Wu that "whenever this sign's not in its usual place, it means I need you upstairs for something."[18] At the beginning, Wu was frightened for he knew that to have an affair with Division Commander's wife is not what he is supposed to do. There is a rule that he has recited many times before coming to the

[15] A Hukou is a record in the system of household registration required by law in China. Because of the huge difference between rural and urban residency status, people used to prefer City Hukou to Countryside Hukou. The Hukou system is regarded as a caste system of China and is in the process of being reformed at present.

[16] Yan (2007, p. 3).

[17] Ibid.

[18] Ibid., p. 10.

Commander's house—"do not do what one is not supposed to do and do not say what one is not supposed to say". But compared with another possible outcome that he would be sent back to the barracks, and never have the chance to be promoted or get his family City Hukou, he was in a dilemma of choosing between surrendering to the seduction of Liu Lian or remaining faithful to his own family and morality. At this period of hesitation, he was admonished again by his Political Instructor, that to serve the Division Commander and his family members is exactly the meaning of "Serving the People". So he came back to his hunter, who then told him that she had decided to let him go back to his hometown and stay with his wife forever. With this tremendous threat as a stimulus, Wu fell to his knees before Liu Lian begging for another chance. Here the previously reluctant prey has totally surrendered himself to the hunter and is willing to do anything that he is told to do, such as taking off his clothes piece by piece in front of her, etc. In order to get the minimal chance of a better living, Wu Dawang, a member of the "people" who should be served according to the previous instruction of Mao is not served by those of higher ranks at all. Here comes the crucial question raised by this fiction: Who are the "people"? Are they the masses who had supported the Eighth Route Army or New Fourth Army to get the control of the government? Or are they the leaders who have been given power to determine little potatoes' fate? The answer given in the fiction of *Serve the People* obviously points to the latter and Yan Lianke deliberately deconstructs a widely accepted truth about "serving the people." He makes use of the drastic verbal parody to deny it and discloses an opposite factual connection in an extremely sarcastic way, which will be further analyzed in the following section.

Parody and rethinking of justice and fear

In Yan Lianke's fiction, the wooden sign "serve the people" plays a crucial role in the development of plot and undergoes changes in its symbolic meaning as a powerful parody. In this aspect, there is a similarity between this fiction and Hawthorne's *Scarlet Letter.* In Hawthorne's novel, the scarlet letter "A" is meant to be a mark of shame for Hester, for letter "A" represents Hester's un-repented "adultery" which initially ostracizes her from the community. But Hester does not surrender to the judgment towards her from the community and defiantly embroiders a beautiful Letter "A" on her coat. Later with her kind nature and willingness to tend the sick and help with the public service, gradually the meaning of "A" is changed, for it is interpreted by the community as "Able"; and finally "Angel". Though the plots of two fictions share nothing in common, the symbolic signs play a similar function, which is to reveal the writers' meditation on what is right or just. What is justice? Etymologically speaking, it comes from Latin word "justus" and "jus" means "right" or "lawful". The change of the symbolic meaning of Letter "A" is finally realized because Hester believes in the moral law within her heart and persistently tries to justify it in the community and change the negative "A" into a positive "A". *Serve the People* also contains a highly symbolic social meaning of sublime justice the first time it is used in the 1944 speech. Mao used it to call people's attention to the necessity of remembering people's interests.

As at that time, a large number of poor Chinese people, especially farmers and workers were expecting equality with those who had money (say rich bankers) or power (regional warlords). The phrase "serve the people" at that time had a highly positive social significance and it was a good timing for Mao to populate that idea so as to win more support for the revolutionary cause. In 2005, Yan Lianke used it as the title of his fiction again and it was also a good timing. The reaction from the government is suggested to be viewed as a piece of evidence. It irritated the authority so much that all the issues of *Huacheng Magazine* which contained this novella were recalled. Another reason of its good timing lies in the fact that it was published 60 years after Mao's speech and 60 years is an important time span. According to traditional Chinese way of recording days and years, there are Heavenly Stems and Earthly Branches (known as Tiangan and Dizhi in Chines), which form a sexagenary cycle.[19] So 60 years mean a full circle and a round of reincarnation with rebirth of old things. By deconstructing the sublime significance of "Serve the people", the fiction depicts a background that 60 years after Mao's famous speech, the interests of the masses are still not fully paid attention to by the authorities and ordinary people still have to serve those who have official power. Obviously this phenomenon goes against what Maoism or Marxism used to suggest when planning for the future of a socialist country. In the 1940s, the masses in China wholehearted supported the Communist Party, because they abhorred those who bullied them and wanted to experience justice with the help of Communist Party. 60 years later, there are still people who are bullied and kicked around by some merciless and immoral authorities. The ironic parody of the state slogan deconstructs completely its authenticity and forcefully tears off the hypocritical veil of certain authorities. The parody here is obviously a deconstruction, but what is to be constructed after the deconstruction?

Usually this fiction is read as a story about the love affairs between a lower ranking solider and a Division Commander's sex-starved wife centering on a wooden sign of "serve the people"; or a parody of a historical discourse with insinuation of ridiculous Chinese political life. There is also a third way to read it. This fiction could be interpreted as a meditation about fear. If one segregates the development of Wu and Liu's love affairs into 4 stages (1. Wu Dawang's heart and soul service towards the Division Commander and his wife for 6 months; 2. Liu Lian's seducing Wu when the impotent Commander was away from home; 3. Wu and Liu's Adam-and-Eve-like life for days inside the Commander's house; 4. Wu's being demobilized so as to be kept away from Liu Lian) and studies each section in detail, one could find that in every stage, fear is involved.

At the first stage, it was because of the fear towards the authorities that Wu dare not doubt or challenge any word by the Division Commander and he took the wooden sign of "serve the people" as the highest command towards him. He followed the principle that "to work at the commander's home is to serve the people" and "not to say what should not be said and not to do what should not be

[19] Though this timing system is no longer used in the contemporary official calendar in China, it still continues to play a significant role in contemporary Chinese astrology and fortune telling, etc.

done." No one can deny that with this fear in mind, Wu was tremendously careful and meticulous in his work.

At the second stage, when the Division Commander had to go away for a 2-month-long conference to discuss plans for army force reductions. The middle-aged but beautiful Liu Lian attempted to seduce Wu. She continuously made use of Wu Dawang's awe towards the wooden sign of "serve the people" in the house and told Wu to follow the direction of the wooden sign. It was because of the fear of losing the chance of being promoted that Wu surrendered to Liu Lian's temptation after a hesitant and wavering period. It should be mentioned that The Chinese pronunciation of the name "Liu Lian" is also a homonym of "durian", "king of fruits" with a strong odour and formidable thorn-covered husk. The soft flesh inside is regarded fragrant and delicious by some people, but there are also many others who feel its aroma overpowering and revolting. "Liu Lian" seems to be a durian to Wu Dawang, as he viewed her as a thorn-covered figure at the beginning, but later he started to find her not so fearsome, instead, rather edible or even delicious.

At the third stage, after the hunted, Wu Dawang, has sexually satisfied Liu Lian many times, he more or less found the glory of being a hunter, as Liu Lian treated him like a husband. For 3 days, they stayed indoors totally naked. When they got hungry, they ate; when they got tired, they slept; when they woke up, they made love. It seems that Wu Dawang's fear has gradually disappeared. When realizing that making love might get boring, Liu trapped Wu to tip over a statue of Chairman Mao and got it broken. Liu then pretended that she was going to report Wu to the military police immediately. With this unprecedented terrifying fear, Wu made ardent love with Liu and brought her higher level of satisfaction. After realizing the unexpected power of fear in their sexual relationship, they destroyed all the revolutionary objects that they could find in the house and made unrestraint love. So, to promote the sexual relations and orgasm between them, not only the wooden sign of "Serve the People!" is applied, but also other methods, such as crushing chairman Mao's plaster, tearing Mao's Anthology or portraits with Lin Biao, or posters of the "highest order" and so on. Till this point, the story goes to the exaggeration: Yan Lianke deconstructs not only the meaning of "Serve the People" from a political slogan to a sexual gadgets, but also many other political symbols in China. The transformation of the traditional political symbols is as absurd as Kafka's *The Metamorphosis*, and its significance in the twenty first century in China is as enormous as that of Kafka's novella in the twentieth century in the western world. What's more, as a Franz Kafka Prize winner in 2014, Yan Lianke is not only good at metamorphosed narration of the truth; he is also familiar with contemporary western literary theory such as Foucault's power relationships in society, as well as Freudian psychoanalysis. And the fiction *Serve the people* exemplifies how craftily he combines the two. It should be mentioned that Yan Lianke is not only a prominent writer, but also a professor of literature at Renmin University in China. He graduated from Henan University in 1985 with a degree in politics and education, and from the People's Liberation Army Art Institute with a degree in Literature in 1991. His education background indicates that he has significant familiarity with western literary theory which was in its heyday in 1980s and 1990s in China. Thus it is argued that at the third stage, the possible psychological

explanation for it is that fear itself does have a stimulating effect. Fear functions as the tool to arouse and add up the characters' sexual desire. By releasing the long-hidden fear pressed upon them—the fear that makes them dare not show any sign of disloyalty to the authority, they recovered another sense of freedom. And here comes another twist of the plot, when they both surrender to the human primal nature, gradually, the hunter willingly becomes the prey of the hunted; they enjoyed themselves like Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden. Surprisingly, when they are naked before their primitive need, there is a sort of equality between them. Liu Lian wants to serve Wu Dawang too, such as cooking for him or feeding him. So far this subversive story not only satires ideology, ambition and conformity, but also leads readers to sympathize with the newly found love between Liu Lian and Wu Dawang. Subconsciously, readers might expect that the writer of this story would arrange a happy ending of Wu Dawang and Liu Lian staying together, for example, running to a faraway place, enjoying their love till the end of their life. There are examples in the fiction for them to follow: the Division Commander's ex-wife has divorced him and sought for her own freedom.

However, the fiction does not go in this direction. At the fourth stage, Liu Lian was asked by Wu if she could go away with him instead of continuing her sexless marriage with the Division Commander, and her answer is negative. When asked the reason, she replied that because that's a man reaching the rank of the Division Commander, she wouldn't divorce him. She refused to divorce him, not because of her love toward him, but because of his official rank. What does that rank represent to her? It represents the possibility that she could ask people like Wu Dawang to serve her. From this point, it could be seen that she is also a prisoner of fear, for fear of losing certain privileges lets her surrender to power. Thus it is argued that throughout the fiction "fear" plays a crucial role. Fear of losing the chance of being promoted to officialdom and fear of being punished as a traitor, urged Wu Dawang to let go his reasoning, self-control and morality. Fear of losing her privilege of an officer's wife jailed Liu Lian inside a house with a husband she does not love.

Besides Wu and Liu, these two leading figures in the fiction, all other characters also live in the shadow of fear. The Division Commander fears that his family secret would be known by others, or Wu Dawang might cause any unexpected trouble, thus it is arranged that Wu should be sent to demobilization as quickly as possible, and "every last detail had been taken care of—urgently and meticulously, and far, far above Wu Dawang's head". It is speculated that the Commander's fear is also partly the reason of his disbanding his unit. All the other soldiers and officers in the fiction are also beseiged in the state of fear. After visiting his wife and family in the country side, Wu returned to the barrack only to find chaos and fear everywhere. The soldiers and their leaders had got some information about the disbanding, but they did not know the details. They were in a jittery state, waiting for the uncertain fate. These soldiers joined the army under the belief of "Protecting the Motherland" and "Serving the People", but all of them also cherished dreams that they might be promoted or get rid of their fate of being a farmer for their whole life. But it turned out, they would all be sent back home with only one exception—Wu Dawang who was accorded military honors and the title of a model soldier and thus would be

given opportunities of working and living in the city together with his family members. At this point, the leaders in the army still remember to promote the notion of "serving the people". "The Head of Management and the Political Instructor jointly exhorted the assembled company to learn from Comrade Wu Dawang's example, reminding their audience that the People only remembered and helped those who selflessly served them. If they all gave something of themselves, as Wu Dawang had, the army would help them, just as they had helped Wu Dawang find a job that would enable him to continue making the utmost contribution to socialism."[20] Ironically, it was this Political Instructor who later begged Wu to say some good words for him in front of Liu Lian so as to avoid the fate of being sent back to the countryside. The soldiers in the fiction may not know what is going on, but readers are clear that here the "people" who rewarded Wu Dawang, does not refer to the mass or the people, but to those who had power. Wu got what he had dreamed of, not because of his whole-hearted housing service to the Division Commander's family (his instructor has also done that before), but because he has made Liu Lian pregnant. Standing in front of his fellow soldiers, Wu Dawang could not reveal the truth, so he remained silent. His silence represents the silence of all those who were forced to bend themselves to power for fear of losing the tiny chance of life. People in this fiction are victims of the fear towards power, and another fear, which is also universal, is fear towards money. As Uruguayan writer Eduardo Galeano points out in his *Book Upside Down: A Primer for the Looking-Glass World*, that all people are in a world of fear and crippled by fear. According to him, they are all captive of fear, no matter those on the top, or on the bottom, or in the middle. The powerful are fearful of losing the control over the oppressed and the oppressed live in the fear of losing whatever little they have, "fear of living, fear of falling, fear of losing your job, your car, your home, your possessions, fear of never having what you ought to have…."[21] Fear drives countries, economies and destinies and many people choose to live in their own little comfortable bubbles in order to avoid confronting their fears.

Fear teaches people to look for any possible way towards security instead of justice. The fiction *Serve the People* in a certain way reveals a truth to readers that it is only when free of fear that one could get real freedom and true understanding of humanity and justice. Wu Dawang has never reasoned the justice of serving the Division Commander and his family, for there is only fear or awe within him. He fears the Commander, who is the highest officer he has ever encountered; he fears losing the post, which is the only way that he could realize his dream of getting his family members a better future; He served them heart and soul but it is a deviated concept of the original "serve the people" which was to bring justice to the masses. All the other soldiers and officers at the barrack are also blind to justice as they are imprisoned by fear too. They follow the order and fear of being punished or demobilized, which deprives them of their chances to reason whether there is justice from the authorities. Justice is an abstract word in the fiction, and the concrete manifestation of justice here is every soldier's wish to live in a better situation, or

[20] Yan (2007, pp. 203–204).

[21] Galeano (2001, p. 19).

that they would be respected and their own dignity could be preserved. When they are drilling hard for the peace of the whole country, they have the right to be respected by the authorities. J. M. Coetzee has a comment on the ethic of authenticity, "being authentic includes being able to lie and steal and cheat as long as you don't pretend to yourself that you are not a liar and a thief and a cheat."[22] Psychologically speaking, moral people would be spiritually tortured if they realize that they are not preserving the justice and it is because the authorities have the power and chance not to pretend, it is easier for the authorities rather than for the masses to abandon their primary commitment to justice and equality. The fiction *Serve the People* vividly reveals how the power enables people to discard justice and equality easily. Just because she is the Division Commander's wife, Liu Lian could let another human kneel down in front of her, and she represents those who apply the authority or authenticity in a negative way. But one point should be mentioned that not all the time that Liu is superior to Wu, for there is a time that spiritual equality arises when they lost themselves in sensual enjoyment. Liu appears in a form of traditional docile wife and Wu a cocksure husband. In front of human's natural sexual instinct, the worldly official rank stops functioning. The disadvantage of this fiction also comes out of this sort of arrangement of the plot. Yan Lianke's making use of the political slogan "Serve the people" intertexually is exemplarily well done, but his choosing to let the two main characters resolve the issue of justice by relying on the male sexual potency or human's primary sexual desire, weakens his fiction's satirical force. Nevertheless, Wu Dawang and Liu Lian did find out a way to stay in the space of love so as to make fear an impossibility. So to meditate on the ending of the fiction, there is still the question of whether the justice is obtained. On the surface, Wu Dawang has got what he wanted, for he and his family members were finally able to live in the city, besides he has got an unforgettable experience of exotic love affair with a "durian-like" woman; but if it is studied further, because of the lack of justice, what he has got is only poetic justice. Because the way he got what he has dreamed of is not sublime, he, together with the Division Commander, and Liu Lian, will always live in the fear of someone else knowing what had really happened. What is more, Wu Dawang would never be able to see his own child born by Liu Lian.

Besides the defect mentioned above, generally speaking, the fiction *Serve the People* is rather a forceful novella which depicts the pervasiveness of fear and reveals the author's endless seeking for justice. In 1944, the slogan of "serve the people" was wholeheartedly welcomed by the people who were seeking for justice, roughly 60 years later in 2005, Yan wrote a fiction bearing the same title to remind people that though this concept has been taken for granted verbally, it has not been achieved in the long period of practice actually. Through the transformation and deconstruction of the meaning of the key phrase, Yan Lianke's hypertext draws readers to the denotation and connotation of the word "people" step by step and triggers them to question who are "the people" that are served. Justice, love and fear are closely knitted together. Where there is no genuine love, there is no justice, and both those in power and those without power live in fear, having no freedom to face

[22] Coetzee and Kurtz (2015, p. 85).

or speak out the truth. Yan Lianke's fiction reminds readers again that they are all the captives of fear, but have not realized their actual state of being prisoners. People think that only those prisoners of the penal system, who wear numbers on their chests, are genuine prisoners, but it turns out to be wrong. In fact most people live in fear and if they want to break free, only genuine love together with responsibility such as what Hester's angel-like "A" represents, could save them and also save the world from injustice. Only by genuine love, could fear be chased away. As Yan pointed out in his Kafka Prize acceptance speech titled "Seeking the light", "[T]he most powerful and frightening darkness comes from people's accommodation and surrender to the darkness, forgetting the light, hence the greatness of literature demonstrates, because only literature can find the weakest and tiniest ray of light, beauty, warmness and honest love in the dark."[23] Seeking for justice or "Seeking the light" is a universal theme and in the fiction of *Serve the people*, it was wrapped in a most daring, sensually shocking but imaginative way. By borrowing and deconstructing the meaning of this worldly well-known phrase—"Serve the people", Yan Lianke metaphorically reveals his abhorrence and objection toward political injustice in China and exposes both the politicians and the masses before the issue of "serving the people". Though the fiction is set in a Chinese cultural space, its implication and significance go beyond any particular political regime.

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[23] http://www.chinadaily.com.cn/culture/2014-10/29/content_18818584_3.htm/ 10. October, 2015.